

insight ■ palladium

thinking in a Brand New way

Microsoft's Palladium is all set to secure the computing world in ways unimaginable...we find out

Security has been reduced to an 'all talk and no show' buzzword that is so typical of today's fast and furious world. You can keep your virus definitions updated, configure your favourite e-mail client such that it does not automatically execute attachments and hope that your children do not stumble onto adult Web sites while surfing. You can try to avoid spam by using a number of whitelists, blacklists and mail filtering services. You can hide your personal data within encrypted partitions and folders to save it from the prying eyes of spyware. With all these measures, things ought to be fine and secure in the computing world. But reality dictates otherwise; security and privacy are community-derived—you cannot hope to be secure even if one person on your network does not take the same defensive measures that you do. You cannot afford to pretend that your server is safe when all it takes is just one mouth to utter a vital password. You certainly cannot pretend that your kids are safe from the social scum that seemingly influence a large chunk of

the content on the Internet.

The trick apparently, is to make security ubiquitous—like the buzzword that it is, but only practically implemented and not verbally announced. If everyone is secure and every computer 'trusts' every other machine, there is little reason to be afraid of a malicious hack or attack. Thus goes the thinking behind some new-fangled initiatives that are meant to bring together the seemingly dichotomous boons of security and privacy within the same computer. We take a close look at one such initiative, Microsoft's Palladium, with the intent of offering an insight into both the workings of the technology involved and the implication that it will have on the way we work and communicate.

Think different

Palladium is a content-protection concept that has spawned from the belief that the PC, as it currently stands, is not architecturally equipped to protect a

user from the pitfalls and challenges that an all-pervasive network such as the Internet poses. A drastic change in the PC hardware is not feasible largely to economic reasons. What Microsoft hopes to introduce is a mid-range change that will serve the dual purpose of granting a computer user security even as it maintains backward compatibility with existing applications.

These changes will be reflected in the key components of the computer: the processor, a motherboard chip, memory devices and output components such as the graphics processor. Palladium is a separate operating system; rather than being based on low-level changes to the Windows kernel itself. Secondly, it is designed as an enforcer of security measures that will either be defined

IMAGING: Solomon Lewis